

on the personal information of members who participate and contribute in the online network. These personal profiles contain information from relationship status to member's religion and sexual orientation, and are shared with their friends and the extended community online. Some sites like Friendster allow viewing of a reduced profile by anyone.

Explicit Relationships.

The main purpose of social networking sites is the explicit representation of relationships. Different social networking sites have different approaches with respect to representing social relationships and what a user of the site can do with this representation. Social networks are essentially about people and their relationships. Three types of social networking relationships are observed, and can be evaluated through the different kinds of intended audience for these types of sites.

Several sites like Friendster, Tribe and orkut are aiming at leisure and social activities. Other sites such as LinkedIn, Spoke and Ryze are aiming at the professional business user. A third type of site that organizes members for social events offline has been termed a real world events site. Meetup are catering for a niche in the different types of communities that are appearing online, by facilitating the way people can arrange and self organize one another and their groups to meet offline. The purpose and aim of the specific social networking site influences the way in which the site is designed and what information gathered through the user profiles will be displayed to which particular users.

In general, a social network is a set of people connected by a set of socially meaningful relationships. Online relationships are based more on shared interests and less on social characteristics. The recent crop of social networking sites that have appeared are based on the concept of six degrees of separation. Once members have contributed their information to the networks, there appears to be several depths to their online relationships that they can share with other members.